Upahar, he noted the Guru's contempt for wealth and projected him as his ideal Indian leader. Indeed, he was not alone. A host of Bengalis, living a thousand miles away from Punjab, had written in praise of Guru Gobind Singh, admiring the spirit of martyrdom and of self-sacrifice of the Sikhs. Bengali monographs like *Sikher Balidan* (1904), *Sikhi-Itihas* (1907) and *Sikher Jagaran* (1929) provided an added stimulus to India's fight for freedom, so that many of these works were rigorously suppressed by the British for their avowed appeal to the militant nationalists of Bengal. *Sikher Athmauti*, for example, was so effectively proscribed by the colonial government that not a single copy of it can be found in any leading library in India.[10]

Unlike Gandhi, who alienated not only the Muslims of India but also the Sikhs, Bhagat Singh made no such mistake when it came to the various communities of India. He and his colleagues in the HSRA understood the imperatives of the world capitalist economy, and this is what gave him his popular appeal. Where they were vulnerable was in their weaker organizational structure compared to what Gandhi had achieved in the Congress Party. Nevertheless, their mass popularity meant that they could cut across caste, creed, race and religion so that they were popular no less with Muslims and Sikhs as they were with the majority Hindu population, and this was their distinctive and under-appreciated strength. Their political radicalism was born out of an acute understanding of the class structure of colonialism, which they had dissected by way of a non-religious and analytical discourse. As such, unlike the Congress Party, they had no wish to see the substitution of a foreign imperialist capitalist class by an indigenous Indian capitalist class. On the contrary, what they envisioned was the advent of the rule of labour over what had previously been the rule of capital.[11] It was underpinned by the fact that unlike the revolutionary zeal of the communists of India, Bhagat Singh's radicalism had the advantage over other left-wing movements of being home grown and anchored in the Indian psyche. What the 1931 hanging of Bhagat Singh deprived an emerging India of, as Pritam Singh reminds us, was 'a serious contest between the Gandhi-led Congress vision and the Bhagat Singh-led socialist